

The Burkean Parlor Metaphor: Argument as Unending Conversation

The Burkean parlor is a metaphor introduced by philosopher and rhetorician Kenneth Burke (1897-1993) for “the ‘unending conversation’ that is going on at the point in history when we are born.” As you read through Burke’s description below, think about a topic which humans have always discussed vigorously from different perspectives, such as large government versus small government, protection versus privacy, etc., and view the metaphor through that lens.

The Burkean Parlor Metaphor

“Imagine that you enter a parlor. You come late. When you arrive, others have long preceded you, and they are engaged in a heated discussion, a discussion too heated for them to pause and tell you exactly what it is about. In fact, the discussion had already begun long before any of them got there so that no one present is qualified to retrace for you all the steps that had gone before. You listen for a while until you decide that you have caught the tenor of the argument; then you put in your oar. Someone answers; you answer him; another comes to your defense; another aligns himself against you, to either the embarrassment or gratification of your opponent, depending upon the quality of your ally’s assistance. However, the discussion is interminable. The hour grows late, you must depart. And you do depart, with the discussion still vigorously in progress.”

Kenneth Burke, *The Philosophy of Literary Form: Studies in Symbolic Action* 3rd ed. 1941.
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